Selection and preservation of flowers

1. Flowers should be collected either early morning or evening.
2. Select buds or flowers just blossoming than flowers in full bloom. These flowers are liable to shed their petals or droop and wither fast in a short period.
3. The stems should not be broken with the hand. It should be cut with scissors or a sharp knife. The stem should be as long as possible.
4. The cut portion of the stem should be immersed in water. Only the petals of the flowers should be exposed.
5. The leaves close to the base of the stem should be removed.
6. The flowers should be wrapped either in a piece of paper or a broad leaf, such as the banana leaf, above the stem ends and stored in dark corner of a room in a bucket of water, to protect them from sunlight. If they are not going to be used soon, polythene covers may also be used to cover the cut flowers.
7. The container or the vase should be filled with warm water. The water should be changed every day. Add sugar or salt to enable the flower to last.

2. Selection of Vases/ Containers

The main function of the vases or container is to support the flowers and foliage. The container should be subordinate to the flower arrangement. It should be of the right size, shape, colour and material.

Types of vases or containers

- Jars, attractive bottles, tins.
- Tall cylinders, narrow necked vases, flat round dishes, deep trays, low round bowls.
- Bottles of different colours.
- Block of wood or bamboo baskets.
- Household pots, vessels, tumblers, shallow dishes.

3. Flower Holder

A flower holder is one which has sharp spikes upon which the stems can be firmly placed. This is known as pin type holder. Other than this we also have crumpled wire, split twigs etc. Flower holders must be strong and flexible, so that any type of stem can be easily fixed.

It should also be rust proof. Pin holders can be fixed to the bottom by clay or candle. This fixing must be done when the vase as well as the holders are dry. Large flowers and foliage can be arranged at the bottom so that the holders are concealed. **Oasis** is a trademarked name for wet **floral foam**, the spongy phenolic **foam** used for real **flower** arranging. It soaks up water like a sponge and acts both as a preservative to prolong the life of the **flowers** and a support to hold them in place.

5.8.2 Styles in flower arrangement

1. **The traditional style:** Where a mass of flowers of all kinds, colours and size are used together. This produces a multi-coloured mass effect.

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